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Nick Mondello

Nick Mondello is a well-known personality in the jazz world. His contributions include numerous record reviews, public relations, distinctive trumpet recordings, and a never-ending enthusiasm for the music and its performers.

Nick was interviewed via Zoom on October 19, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive and I'm very pleased to have Nick Mondello with me today, and it's sort of 10:30 a.m., not really jazz hours, but welcome.

NM: Monk, thank you so much, and thank the Fillius Jazz Archive and Hamilton College and Joe Williams up there in the great 52nd Street in the sky like Bill McCann used to say. Thank you so very much. I'm really privileged and humbled.

MR: Normally I would say a list of what musicians do and what their gig is, but because you're a guy who works with words a lot, I'm going to offer you a chance to introduce what your life's work has been.

NM: Wow. Okay. I am, for lack of a better word, a free-lance trumpeter, primarily a jazz trumpeter who also is able and does a lot of work writing. And that extends into some other activities which sort of is a logical progression, sort of like the 2-5-1 of life. But that kind of moved into consulting, production consulting and creative consulting and other things, book consulting. It's kind of like someone said to me one time, "What is it that you do?" So I says, "I'm kind of like Monty Rock III from the old 'Tonight Show.'" "What do you do?" "I'm a celebrity." That's what he used to say. Either that or like the Banana Man you know, from Captain Kangaroo. But I do a lot of different things in the jazz world, and some things outside of the jazz world as well, and I have an awful lot of fun. In most cases it's a labor of love and like I say, things seem to lead on and on and on. There's always something. It's sort of like you know those domino videos you see on YouTube you know. One leads to the next to the next, and it keeps me pretty busy and I really, really enjoy doing what I am doing. I teach as well online and in some cases in person, and clinics and just a little bit of everything. But right now I would say predominantly I'm working in my writing and consulting work.

MR: Would you think, would all those dominoes have started and fallen into place if you hadn't been a player first? And what I mean by that is sometimes I'm fascinated by people who are tremendous fans of the music or they make a living as perhaps a jazz journalists but they weren't players first. So did your trumpet playing lead to all these things?

NM: Great question, and I did think about that. I'll be honest with you I thought about that before this interview. I've been truly, truly blessed to come from a family, not so much of musicians although there were some, two of the paternal great, great, great whatever back in Italy were bandmasters. And when I was a youngster at about five years old one of my uncles was a student of Doc Cheatham. He was a semi-pro trumpet player. But here's the thing. There was always pervasive music in the household, predominantly from the women singing. So you grow up hearing all of these Sophie Tucker tunes and Fanny Brice tunes and tunes from the 20s and whatever. And my father, he knew Al Jolson. That's how far back he went, okay? So in his case it was always all of the Al Jolson tunes. "Avalon," "Sonny Boy" as a matter of fact "Sonny Boy" was one of the first tunes I remember as an infant. So there was always this music, musical environment, all the time. So it was almost a logical progression that music would take hold in some capacity, whatever it was. So having an uncle that played the trumpet, somehow I got a trumpet. I don't recollect how. It certainly wasn't like Clark Terry with the hosaphone but I started lessons with an old-time trumpet teacher named Felix Sangenito who has taught a number of very, very fine players including — I'm trying to remember his name, it'll come to me in a second — but he's taught a lot of guys, especially here on Long Island. So it was very much a progression. It was almost like no one forced you into this, but it was osmosis, okay? You know? You know I tell people the DNA is five lines and four spaces. And it was always like that. So you always were involved in the school band and what-have-you. And again, shortly after that things started to open up outside the family. They used to take me around as a little kid playing at things like weddings, you know, let's bring the little kid up and have him play, you know, "Come Back to Sorrento" or something like that you know. Like what Frankie Avalon did in some of his video clips. Right? So you'd be playing these Italian weddings as like, "Bring the kid up," you know let him do his thing. But of course there were no smart phones or video cameras back then. So you did that kind of thing. And then I remember taking me around to like political get-togethers for — this guy's running for mayor, let's have this kid come and play whatever. So he got a couple of Italian votes. You know and then like I say, things started to move outside of the family but it was reinforced by the family.

[7:45]

MR: So let me ask you a question, and first of all I'm going to ask you can you move back just a little bit? Yeah. Perfect.

NM: Okay.

MR: So we'll just snip this out.

So when you're playing at these Italian weddings and so forth, do you recall the first time you played something on your trumpet that was spontaneous? That was perhaps the forerunner of improvising for you?

NM: That was always there in some way shape or form. It was always there. Some of that emanated from copying or imitating, hearing that particular song. Some of it was clams okay? You know? But maybe a lot of it was clams. "He's got squingili in his "Comeback to Sorrento." You know? But the improvisational thing was another thing that was picked up from the listening, from the records. Doc Cheatham. And then I remember getting sheet music of Rex Stewart solos. Rex Stewart cornet solos that were transcribed. And I think my uncle had given them to me. So it was sort of like another kind of natural creative schtick you know.

MR: And it sounds like you eased into it and so that you weren't afraid of it. I know, I taught a lot of junior high kids and the idea of improvising was frightening. And I think it's partly because they didn't have that experience you're talking about, that the music was around them.

NM: Very, very good point. I see that and have seen that in my years teaching. I've always felt that younger students have an innate creative ability to, what we would call improvise, in many different ways. You see that in art work, you see that in their speaking. The thing about offering jazz improv "quote quote" to let's say a fifth or sixth grader, okay, is — it can be as you say very, very intimidating. Students, and you know this, at that age, you know, they don't want to be ridiculed and they don't want to be heckled. However, once you can ease that hesitation, and there are ways to do that that you kind of learn over the years okay? Now you're not going to have a sixth grade kid, you know, improvising like John Coltrane, okay, unless your name is Clovis Grognuz over in Switzerland. I don't know if you've ever seen him.

MR: I have not.

NM: Oh you've got to check him out. I mean this kid, and I had an opportunity to profile him. He literally — he's a savant and he's learned Bird solos, Coltrane solos, Dexter Gordon solos. Note for note. And he's done it this way. He doesn't follow the process of looking at a transcription, playing the notes and then you know, he goes the other way, which is of course the way a lot of older players have learned you know. But I'll tell you, as an educator, one little trick that I've used with a lot of success — and the thing about it is that once the kids do that, "Hey man look at me, this is pretty cool, I just played along with — you know you put on an Aebersold or you know some YouTube downloaded backing track. Maybe it's just like a rock guitar with a rhythm section, and you give the kid two notes, a G and an F. Okay? On the horn. And then you know I pick up the horn, you play those two notes, the kid plays it. No music. Then you embellish the two notes

and then that two notes becomes a little more involved rhythmically and you try to keep it within the technical abilities of the student, which is of course the teacher's responsibility, and then you tell the student, "You know what you have done? You have just played jazz. You have just improvised, okay?" And then you — and again this is things that have worked. I mean there are things that I've done that just fell flat as a flat tire okay. But you want to get the child or the student feeling confident about having done something in a very small way.

MR: Exactly.

NM: And then it just goes on and on and on from there. And when you get the "I don't know what to play" comment, okay, well try to play what I'm going to play for you. And then of course from the two notes to the three notes to maybe a version of a scale, don't get into any theoretical circle of fifths or anything like that, because then you wind up with the intimidation, and oh my God it's like the Periodic Table of the Elements. "I can't handle that."

MR: I couldn't agree more.

NM: So it's a very, very, very deep point that over time, and this is one of the blessings about getting older, after a while you try things, they work, they don't work, you bomb, and you get the kids. Another thing like that is I don't primarily like to teach from the method books, okay? Now every student at some point in time when they're in the school they're going to get the Belwin Band Builder or the this or what-have-you. So there are concepts that I embellish or I take from the Belwin Band Builder let's call it, or whatever it happens to be, and I write tunes for the kids, okay? And then of course you make silly names for the tunes like "Parade of the Peppy Pickled People" or something stupid like that, and it's all about entertaining. Because we are entertainers by our nature. It's innate, see? We happen to be teachers, and entertaining, encouraging, motivating and then being prepared for when failure happens, you know, with the kids. You know it's something interesting, and I hope I'm not running on on this, but when you're here, you know, teachers say, you know, "I asked this kid about Charlie Parker and you know he didn't know anything about Charlie —" well the kid's a sixth grader or seventh grader, whatever grader he happens to be. You know it's our job to at least introduce not only who and what, when and where, but why — why Charlie Parker? Why Dizzy Gillespie and all — why the great vocalists you see? And getting them to buy into that, once they do, you know they say you know what? We trust this man or woman that's teaching us, and apparently you know he must know his stuff or else they just grabbed him in from central casting. You know? Bring in a music teacher, here you go. But you know that's a big, big, and I learned that, I'll tell you where I learned that from. I learned that from Clark Terry. I learned that from one of the great music educators out there whose name

you may or may not know, Paul Effman. Okay? Paul, a music educator, came up with a model to have schools in — have music programs in private and parochial schools and eventually it developed into something like seven or eight hundred schools. But the idea was it's entertaining and educational and motivating and something that you will always try to remember.

MR: I'd like to come back to this later on when we talk about jazz education and where it's at, but I wanted to get to your writing. And I want to run some adjectives by you.

NM: Oh boy.

MR: These are Nick quotes:

NM: Oh Lord in heaven.

MR: These are some things you said about different players. "Harmon-muted" "Zottola-buzzing" "Corea fluttering lines," talking about a singer, her approach to the lyrics is pristine and emotive and a tenor player who wails brazenly, energized entitles. All these things were part of your descriptive writing on different recordings. So my question is do you have literally perhaps, a page of adjectives? You know there's that famous saying, "Writing about music is like dancing about architecture." Right?

NM: Yeah, yeah, sure.

MR: Well I'm trying to think every time you sit down to write a review and are you aware of using a particular phrase multiple times? How do you keep your writing fresh from one session to the next?

NM: Very interesting. The writing aspect for me is frankly the easier part. That's number one. I really like — when I'm doing, let's say it's an album review or nowadays a single review. Okay? I have a process that I like to use, which is not only repetitive repetitive listenings, that's number one. I read the liners. When I do the listenings I also, if I'm able to I'll alternate the tracks. Okay? And I do that because sometimes there's a sequence in the production. All right? Which is an art in and of itself from the production side. I'll alternate, I'll shuffle randomly and listen to the track again on its own. Okay? Stylistically I do tend to in some cases be a little Baroque with some of the verbiage, you know a little embellishment. And that's a fine balance between talking specifically about the music itself and describing what my reaction is to the music or to the improvisation, and I don't want to make a supposition that you're going to have the same emotional reaction as I did, for a couple of reasons. One I'm a musician number one, which is a benefit and in a sense it's a little bit of a drawback. Okay? Even though I've done a lot of the reviews, a lot, okay, it's always a skill that I'm trying to get better at. Just like playing the horn okay? But you know you make a really good point. I notice that in my own writing okay? The thing about the Glenn Zottola thing which is really interesting, Glenn is a phenomenal, phenomenal musician. Yes. Incredible, okay? He's another — Glenn is

another savant, all right? Without a doubt. And when Glenn plays, especially when he plays with that Harmon mute, he really gets almost that Miles Davis buzz. Okay? Which is, actually it's an aspect of physics, all right? The vibrations and the pitch, you know, have to be just right for that Harmon mute to really zing. And he is gifted here, with his ear, where he knows that he wants to get that Miles Davis type buzz sound from Miles' earliest days, you know from the Prestige Recordings, "If I Were a Bell" and you know, some of those great classic recordings. But you know the verbiage, again I try to keep that from both a trumpet player/musician perspective and a writing perspective. And hopefully you get a good balance of the two. And I have been criticized for being a little bit too embellishing verbally, and I'll admit that. And then again that's something that one works on. You know it's sort of like how would Ernest Hemingway write this liner notes or album review? Well it's going to be pretty dry. Okay? You know it's almost like the old dollar-a-word kind of commentary. You know write like you're being charged a dollar a word. But I really really do my homework on the listening, man.

MR: Do you ever multi-task when you're listening? Even making coffee or oh I've got to go get the mail and the music's playing, or do you sit and just totally concentrate on the selection?

NM: I'll do that in the car. I like to do that in the car, which is why I bought this car off lease because it still has a CD player. But that's also part of the method of the madness you know. I'll listen to it here and then I'll say you know what? I want to take it for a ride. I'll listen to it in a lot of different ways. I'll listen to a track and only listen to the rhythm section, you know, foregoing the front line.

MR: I had a question about that, I'm glad you said that. If you did a review on a record and let's say it was sort of in — well here we go with labels — but mainstream I guess, and you were struck by how swinging the rhythm section is, for you, what makes that work? What makes that rhythm section swing more than some other ones?

NM: I think that swinging in that particular instance is something that derives an emotional and rhythmic response from me the listener. Okay? One can talk about before the beat, on the beat, behind the beat, you know all that technological stuff, but it's all about emotion. So quite honestly it'll be rare — at least in my experience — where the rhythm section is really swinging and the vocalist or the front line is let's say a little bit less energetic. Okay? You know you have to look at a production in its totality, meaning the front line, the rhythm section, the engineering. I also like to listen to these albums — or tracks — from a production standpoint. Okay? And having done a little bit of that with like Keith Fiala for example, as a matter of fact I have done a lot with Keith on a number of his singles and albums, you learn a little bit more. I mean I know nothing about, you know, sliding and equalizers and phasers and all of that. All I know is what I can hear here and

you know what good balance is, and you know what good mixing is, and you appreciate the production elements and the production values of what goes into the artwork. You know it's almost like, and there are samples of this, it's almost like a beautiful classic painting that has a gaudy, gaudy frame. Okay? And it's like well I'm interested in the Mona Lisa, I'm' not interested in this you know, gilded peeing cherubs and whatever it happens to be. You know? So it really is an immersion. You know? You really immerse yourself into, you know, that's why I get on the album review side a lot of albums to listen to. And you know I tend to be very selective about what I'll listen to. Sometimes that's not a positive because you'll miss something or you won't review an album that really, really is something unique and special.

MR: If you got a CD or multiple tracks, you put something on and it just strikes you that I don't enjoy this at all. Do you go to track two and give it another try? And so this is a multiple point question. If you are requested to review something and you really dislike it for specific reasons, do you review it anyway?

NM: In most cases yes. I try to be fair you know. I'll tell you something interesting, I see that more in reviewing books. Okay? And I'll tell you why and this drives me nuts. With the proliferation of vanity presses you know anybody can publish a book if you want to spend the money on it. So you'll get a book to review where the musician is just an awesome, awesome player but they've used spell check so you get homonym words incorrectly in the spell check. And these are really egregious okay? So you see that. Other kinds — I mean look, you're not reviewing the grammar per se, you are a musician you're not an English teacher and an English expert, but at least from a production standpoint, okay, use something — get a professional proofreader — you know which I've done okay, to literally go through every word. I've seen that on liner notes too, including where the main artist's name is spelled wrong.

MR: Hmm. How about saxophone spelled wrong?

NM: Bingo. Okay? I mean we've seen it all. But again you know then there's a couple of real interesting things there. One is there's a tendency in the production cycle, and I've seen this, for the artist, who is so eager to get the album done and get the album out okay, that certain things tend to not get as much scrutiny as let's say the musical side of it. So I'll say to an artist or an author, "Look if you were doing an album you wouldn't want clams on your record" Okay? I mean really bad clams, okay? Not just improvisational type clams, okay. Why would you want them in your book? Give you another example. And by the way some of these books were terrifically written, terrific books okay? And terrific albums. Another one literally I'm reading the book and the book literally comes — it decomposes in my hands. Now what did you uses, you know the production facility, what did they use, crazy glue? Okay? I mean literally the pages fall apart. As a matter of fact I

just sent a book down, no names, I sent it down to Jai Florada and he said, "What the hell did you do with this book, there's rubber bands all around?" I said, "Well when you read it you've got to hold like one page at a time because they used such an inferior production facility, but the book is wonderful. It's great." So that's something that you encounter more so in the book side of it you know. I don't want to make this like a plug but I'll give you a really good example. Joe LaBarbera, who I know you know and you interviewed all three of my dear brothers, he did a book with Charles Levin on Bill Evans.

MR: Which I'm currently reading.

NM: It's a great, great, great book. And the thing that they did was they, and Charles was basically the production consultant, and he's a former drummer too. They went to North Texas State Press, all right? The book, and my daughter is a librarian so she knows about books. And I showed this book to her and I says, "This is really well manufactured." Of course the book was written incredibly well. It's a great, great, great book. Okay? But they were wise enough to take control over the production, okay, of the book. So I see that more so on the book side than on the album side, but you know most of what I see album-wise, you know, is good and then up to great to phenomenal quality.

MR: Were you — this is a bit of a tangent but — when you were growing up were you an avid reader of LP liner notes?

NM: Yes, although I was an avid reader of everything. Everything. If you look back to liner notes back in the day in more cases than not the liners were pretty top of line, they really weren't, you know, as exhaustive. Let's say something like what Bill Evans did for "Kind of Blue." Okay? Because he was involved of course in the recording too. But I would read them. You know who's the personnel? That was always a big thing too.

MR: Me too. And you had mentioned before we were recording how the tangents in the music world and how it's all this connection and I remember seeing, "Oh Clark Terry's on this record and he was on that other record" and all these just like musical chairs I'd have to say.

NM: Without a doubt. One of the things that I enjoy doing, I'm sure you're familiar with Tom Lawrence Jazz Discography, which is a great, great, great resource, especially for a historian or a writer or what-have-you. But it's always interesting to go in and plug in a name and go back to their early days, okay? I did this recently again with Manny Klein who was a great, great, great trumpet player, great guy, great sense of humor, they'd always make fun of his nose, he made fun of his nose you know. But you go back and you find out that Manny Klein played on all of these records from the 20s, this was before he went to Hollywood you know. And in the same ensembles you see Tommy Dorsey, Jimmy Dorsey, you know other great names. Benny Goodman. You know, they

just went on. The synchronicity thing also, you know there's a lot of chance in the larger sense of the word, in the jazz world. Somebody gets — it's like Lou Gehrig with the guy that couldn't play first base that day, you know a person can't make a gig, all right, they get a sub, and before you know it, if not subsequent to that but when the vocalist leaves that group and goes on to another one, boom he plucks up, you know, that player. So when you go back and you study and look at, if not study this stuff you see all of these sort of random meetings, events. It's like the gal that got discovered at Schwab's Pharmacy in Hollywood. I forget who it was, all right, but that kind of thing is absolutely fascinating and I mentioned before we were recording live, I'm doing a thing now on the comedian Soupy Sales. And a lot of people don't know he was a great jazz lover and he had a radio show in Detroit in the 50s and the theme song was "Yardbird Suite" and Bird was on the show three times, and Miles was on six times, they're all gone. Now Yusef Lateef, okay, and I happened to be talking to Pete Barbutti and I mentioned that I was doing this thing and Pete says, "Oh yeah," he says, "I knew Soupy from before in Toledo. We're old friends, we've been together." The whole nine yards. So you have all of these sort of like circles. It's sort of like a Venn diagram, you know, all of these things, all right? And then in some way, shape or form they come together. I'll tell you another one that was really fascinating. Chuck Findley, who I'm sure you know, one of the great, great, great musicians and great people, I love him. He put something up on FaceBook about his wife's grandmother apparently was a singer. So I thought this was kind of interesting and I would kind of scratch the surface. And the singer's name was Pilar Arcos A-R-C-O-S. And Zelee, Chuck's wife, that's her grandmother. So anyway I start researching Pilar Arcos and as the dominoes fall one thing led to another, and you find out, if I recollect correctly, she came to the U.S. by way of Cuba although that's not where she was originally from I don't think. I don't remember that part, came to the U.S. and was a vocalist and in the 20s, with the advent of I guess 78s, she was one of the foremost recorded artists in New York if not the U.S. And there were all of these recordings, primarily in Spanish, all right, that she sang and she was extremely famous, and she studied with a voice teacher and the person who would follow her or precede her in her lesson was Carlotta Monti who was W.C. Fields' girlfriend. So and then of course it went on to Hollywood, Pilar went on to Hollywood with "I Love Lucy" and Ricardo Montalban and Cesar Romero and all these other people. But the crazy thing about these things is that it's all this in some way, shape or form. Whether it's the hand of God if you think that way as I do, or pure chance, you know this is how a lot of things have happened. And when you kind of dive in, you know which is really the fun thing. You know I must have been like a dachshund in a prior life trying to rat out the rats. But when you start researching this stuff and you turn a page and turn a page and it's absolutely

amazing you know. And it has impact upon the artists and it has impact upon the artist's music, which as a reviewer gives me more ammunition so to speak in terms of what the artist is all about.

MR: I totally agree, that you're being faithful to this person's personality if you happen to know them, and I agree that this music isn't made in a vacuum.

NM: That's right. And how. I did a thing recently, this was another crazy project, on a trumpet player by the name of Rocco Bene. Now I happen to remember his name because in around Philadelphia, Rocco was like the guy, the lead trumpet player. So like in New York you had Bernie Glow, and in Philly you had Rocco, and of course in L.A. later on you had Al Porcino and Wayne Bergeron of course, all these great, great, great, tremendous, tremendous players. So I decided to research Rocco. And I knew about Rocco doing a lot of the Gamble and Huff produced Philadelphia International sides. But I didn't know about the music scene in Philly in which Rocco played before all of the Cameo Parkway records, you know Chubby Checker and Little Eva, "Locomotion" and Fabian. But the crazy thing, you know you keep going you find out they all went to high school together. South Philadelphia High School. All of them. All right? And Cameo was upstairs from a jewelry store. The recording studio was upstairs and it was like bare bones. They had the microphone for the piano, was in the upright piano and all of these Cameo — Chubby Checker, right? That recorded for Cameo, and the guy that owned the jewelry store said, "You know I know a guy who is a producer on this relatively new T.V. show. Do you mind if I kind of mention it?" It turns out that the guy was friends with one of the producers on Dick Clark's American Bandstand.

MR: I knew that was coming.

NM: Yes. All right? So the guys from upstairs on Cameo, Fabian, Chubby Checker, right, they all wound up progressing, you know, onto the other thing. But you know if you dig a little bit and you research, and there's something about research that I'd like to add as well in a second, if you really dig you know you find out that these are important connections and important synchronicities. Okay? The thing about research that, in today's day and age — and I'll make you laugh on this too, is there's so much information out there and verifying the information, confirming the information is really critical. And just like in the book production thing you don't want to have clams and use spell check, you want to verify what your sources are or what-have-you. So as a humorous way of showing what happens today, a number of years ago *All About Jazz* asked me to do a April Fool's spoof review. So what I did was — I've always been a Pee Wee Marquette fan ever since I met him at Birdland, which by the way through the good graces of Jai Florada and his father and his mother, without whom I would never be here, forget about where I am. So Pee Wee Marquette, right? So I write this thing called "The

Lost Introductions of Pee Wee Marquette." Okay? And it was a spoof. And I incorporate the Lester Young thing and the tips and the name Art Blakey, okay? Right? And *All About Jazz* publishes it with a number of other spoof articles on April Fool's Day. Okay? Well a few years later I still was interested in Pee Wee of course. Whatever happened to Pee Wee? And then I found the video clip that he did with David Letterman with his Hawaii Kai outfit and all his medals and his hat and everything, and I kind of lost — there isn't much about him after that. But anyway I'm on Wikipedia and there on Wikipedia there is a CD album called "The Lost Introductions of Pee Wee Marquette."

MR: Oh Lord.

NM: Yeah. So dig this: so I get in touch with Wikipedia and I write them and I say it was a spoof, it's presented as a spoof, please, you know you don't want to have erroneous information on Wikipedia. Okay? Please remove it. They wouldn't remove it. About six months later I get an email from someone I think in India who writes me and says, "Can you provide me the CD?" So it just took on a life of its own. Okay.

MR: Yeah. It's out there and you can't stop it.

NM: That's right. One of the other things, and I'd like to share this with you is there's a wonderful, wonderful musician, incredibly talented arranger/composer, you probably know him. He teaches down in Dallas. His name is Giovanni or Gio Washington-Wright. And he's done tons and tons of transcriptions. I mean he's a genius when it comes to that and playing. But about two years ago Doc Severinsen and his lady friend Catherine Leach, Cathy Leach, Dr. Cathy Leach, came to me and said, "You know there's a lot of misinformation out there as relates who played what on different film soundtracks." Okay? So would you be interested in working with Doc and I on verifying some of this information and obliterating some of the hearsay and that which is not verified? What are you kidding? Do a book with Doc? So I engaged Gio, I engaged Jai Florada. Gio being a historian and very knowledgeable about soundtracks. He also has access through the union to the actual contracts. Okay? So we have started to work on this book which Cathy said to me it may eventually become like a long-form article on verifying who played what when and where, and who it really is. Okay? So we start the research, we start digging in, and I really got into this. Okay? Because I'm a soundtrack fan too. So we got into who played this on this soundtrack and whatever. And we even found out who played overdubbing for Sam Jaffe on "Gunga Din."

MR: The bugle call?

NM: The bugle call. The guy's name was Charles Hamilton and the way I got that was I was watching some old YouTubes of "Gunga Din," "Gunga Din," "Gunga Din," right? And this woman comes on and she says, "That was my uncle, Charles Hamilton. He was a member of the RKO Studio Orchestra." So with Gio's help and Jai's help and Cathy's

research we went back into a lot of these films, even going back to some silent films that had recorded soundtracks on them. Okay? And again, this was an enlightenment, seeing who played what on these recordings. So I'll share something, and this is something I have somewhat of an issue with and it goes back to the idea of verification. I have actually shown the AF of M contract to other musicians and it says right there, "Here's who is playing on this session." Okay? They won't believe it. They won't believe it. So you know there's some stubbornness or ignorance out there, but this idea of too much information, unverified information or in my case spoof information out there, okay, you know it can sabotage our history, our history, which is viable, the history of music, and in this case the history of trumpet in film you know. But that's a long term project that we're having a lot of fun with. And my daughter Amy as I said is a librarian so she's able to get into, as a professional she knows about these databases and different things all around the world, and you can kind of access, legally, all kinds of information about films, recordings, record dates. So it's really a lot of fun. It's a labor of love.

MR: Wow that's fascinating. Have you ever had someone propose that you write an article with a title something like "Is Jazz Dead?" You know every ten years, maybe less than that, it seems like this shows up on the cover of *DownBeat* or *Jazz Times*.

NM: Yep. Yep.

MR: And it's something to write about. Would you take that on?

NM: I don't know. I would be 51 percent no, 49 percent maybe. And I'll tell you why. There has been a lot written about that, a lot discussed about that, it is a philosophical question. It's a question that plays directly into jazz education. It's a question that plays into access to technology. It is a very, very, very deep question that quite frankly I would say I don't care to debate it, all I know is that it is a perennial art form that is a Black-American and American art form that is still evolving. Not only is it evolving but it's like a mobius. It goes back — you know Marsalis is marvelous about doing this, you know going back to its roots, going back to its roots, and then moving ahead and examining different pathways that jazz artists have taken. You know John Coltrane being one of the most avid explorers, Thelonious Monk and many, many, many others. So you know I wouldn't go back and comment well it smells that way, like you hear people say, which is stupid. But it's the kind of thing that let's just say I would have to take a long, long, long walk thinking about if I would want to do it, what are some of the factors both positive and negative. You know it's really interesting in the sense like I say, this plays to jazz education. If jazz is dead why are there so many great high school and college jazz ensembles? Okay?

MR: Right.

NM: If jazz is dead why are there still great schools like Berklee and North Texas State and Miami and whoever else I forgot to mention. Okay? These educational institutions aren't just bringing in students under some kind of a false pretense. The other thing of course is the technological aspect of it plays a really, really, really big role. I'll give you a good example. Before the Covid I went to see Randy Brecker, who is a dear friend, over at the resurrected My Father's Place. And the feature artist there, it was Billy Cobham's group. And they were literally re-living these great Billy Cobham albums that Billy did with Randy, with Michael, God rest his soul, and Paul Hansen, the bassoonist played Michael's parts. Okay. And you know he's a great, great, great jazz bassoonist. I mean he's a monster. But here's my point about the technical. So Randy is playing and he's incorporating you know all of these foot pedals, you know that look like Sam Ash's electronics. There's this one, this one, this one, this one, this one, but of course being the great musician that he is he's using them in a very, very wise way. Point number one. Point number two, you have YouTube, TikTok, in-home studio, in-home video you know, literally anyone can incorporate recording video and audio and present it. So I have young students or new students when I was teaching schools or what-have-you. "Are you a TikTocker?" "Yeah I'm a TikTocker, I have 900,000 you know followers." That's like my grandson says. He's got like 900,000. So I said to him, "What do you TikTok about?" He says, "We TikTok about gaming" or what-have-you. So I says, "Well you ever think about TikToking about a song that you might have heard that really is kind of a re-make of a jazz song? Or a song that's sampled from a jazz song? You know like 'Cantaloupe Island.'" Okay? Or, oh gosh, the pop tune was "Billy Don't Call that Number" — I forget the — they sampled another tune. But you know you say to the young student well that actually came from this here. And it goes back to that question about how come you don't know about Charlie Parker? Well it's our job to tell you about Charlie Parker. Okay? It's our job to get you hooked on it. So if you're savvy enough as an educator and willing to go the extra not even couple of yards, if you're willing to go a couple of inches to bring the jazz experience into what the young students are doing, okay, I mean that is like the bait on the hook that catches the bass. You know? Another quick example: as I mentioned to you before I don't like to use method books per se, you know. I like to entertain. So I write these tunes on Finale. And over the years I've written about 1,200 or so. Some of them are transcriptions. All right? And they're transcriptions of a tune like "Song for my Father." Okay? So we put that song in the — and you know I will modify the tune to make it a little bit easier with the embellishments and the trills and what-have-you, and then we'll listen to the song after we learn it and play it. "You just played that same song, you know, that Lee Morgan played." Okay? And then you go on, and you go on. You know what? It's almost like a seduction. Okay? And once you've

got them hooked, and I'll share one other thing, and I hope I'm not just going on and on — running on here. Okay? What I'd like to do is get students involved in things in addition to their school musical activities. Give you a good example: Trumpet players, would you like to be part of Taps Across America on Veteran's Day or Memorial Day? You'll be seen on YouTube, blah-blah-blah. Okay? We get them to play "Taps." We did a thing with the World Band for a documentary that I'm involved in, an award-winning documentary, they've won in Barcelona and in Charleston already. That documentary is called "Song for Hope." It's about Ryan Anthony, the late Ryan Anthony, the great Ryan Anthony and his cancer and developing "Cancer Blows" which all these trumpet players are involved in. Okay? But they did a thing with the World Band. And, "Would you like to be in the World Band? You're going to be part of 1,300 musicians, pros, young players, classical players, whatever." And you get them involved in something outside of just a school environment. It's an amplification of it. The other thing about that, when we talked about jazz improv before, we talked about the hesitation and the trepidation, you know, to go ahead and play, right? Well they make their videos and they go out and they're performing. It's no different than the talent shows that Jai Florada and I used to do when we were young kids. They used to take us around to the talent shows. You know?

MR: You've come a long way, baby.

NM: Oh I will add one other anecdote, I'll make you laugh. Okay? One of the — this is talking about getting outside the schools. When I was a young kid, my brother played clarinet and he played up through high school and then he became a police officer and detective and you know top, top, top cop. Anyway in those days you could do this, but my mom and aunts, depending on what year it was, would drive us around on Halloween to bars. And we would be in like a hobo outfit and we had this old hat that somebody got from the Salvation Army. Right? And we knew one tune which was basically a blues type thing [scats]. Okay? Right? Like Joe Avery's blues. So we would go to these bars, and you know the drunks, "Hey look at these two little kids" and they would throw money you know. So believe me, in those days it was a lot of bucks. But one gig we go to what used to be a restaurant. It's right around the corner from here and believe me every time I pass it I think of it, a really hoity toity restaurant. So you know my mother says, "Well why don't you go in there, it's a fancy place, there's people that got a lot of money." All right? So my brother and I open the door, we walk in and we just start playing. The maitre d takes the both of us by the scruff of our collar and escorts us not in a very polite way out and throws a nickel and two pennies at us and says, "Get the hell out of here."

MR: Well now I know what you made on your first gig.

NM: Yeah, you know. But it's important to get the kids out and playing.

MR: All right.

NM: That's the key.

MR: I'd like to wrap up with — this is sort of a curve ball.

NM: No problem.

MR: You had mentioned technology and at some point we mentioned 78s. So this is "Body and Soul"/"Foxtrot" Coleman Hawkins and his Orchestra. I wonder if you can imagine, if you were writing reviews back in that time, what was this, late 30s if you think about that recording what would you have — what would have been your entry point? What would you have focused on?

NM: Wow. Normally I try to take some aspect of the recording and bring like a metaphor into it, okay? And then use that as a launch point for the review of the music itself. Okay? So let's say for example "Body and Soul." "Body and Soul" I believe was written by Johnny Green?

MR: Yes. Heyman, Green, there are four names here.

NM: Right.

MR: Yeah.

NM: Okay? So now I'm just doing a stream of consciousness, okay? Johnny Green went to Harvard, okay? He's a very, very well educated person. Maybe there's something there, all right, that can lead me into describing, at least initially, as an entree into this revolutionary recording. Okay? The other thing that I would also do is take somewhat of a comparative approach. Well there were other players of course, before. Historically what sort of influences might have been on Hawkins' style, okay, who guided him in that direction, that influenced him on this particular recording and his other recordings. So you know it's a hard thing to do right now, it's almost like what we said before about is jazz dead. Because there's been so much written about it, so we would have to go back in the H.G. Wells' time machine back to that recording and listen to it with virgin ears. Okay? But again, like I said to you before, I try to take a methodical approach to it and believe me there's lots of dead ends. There's lots of dead ends. But the focus there, and here are some other angles that I might be interested in: What is the interaction of the rhythm section with such a revolutionary approach to improv? Okay? Here's Hawkins really embellishing and playing and you know right from the get-go of his solo, well how is that interacting with the other players who may or may not be at a — while they are great players they may not be at a level of exploration that Hawkins was.

MR: Indeed.

NM: So it's a really, really hard — you know that's an interesting exercise in analysis. That's a really, really, really good question and a really good exercise. And like anything else, sometimes you have to do exercises.

MR: Yeah. If you can fit it into your schedule.

NM: Well you know what? That's a possibility. You know to look at it from virgin ears so to speak, and virgin eyes.

MR: Well I've really enjoyed our conversation.

NM: Oh this has been wonderful. Absolutely wonderful. I can't thank you enough of course, and both Giacomo Gates, my dear friend, the "Genuine One."

MR: Yes indeed.

NM: He really digs that that I call him that. But don't tell him this, I mean he truly is a genuine artist, but I actually picked that up, I stole it from a can of Budweiser, because I saw the word "genuine" and I says you know what? That's Gates. You know Gates carries the torch you know of, you know all of the Eddie Jefferson going all the way back to Pops.

MR: Yep. He's part of that Venn diagram.

NM: Without a doubt.

MR: All right.

NM: Without a doubt. Thank Glenn Zottola as well, my savant friend. Thank you, Hamilton College, Milton Fillius, and the endowment, your jazz archive and Hamilton College's jazz archive is something that, as we said before, that both young students and not-so-young students certainly would benefit tremendously. You know? I think that people — we live in an audio-visual world now, so people, you know TikTok and you know Twitter and all of that stuff, you know having people observe those videos. And you know I mean you've done over 400 of them, right?

MR: Yes.

NM: So I mean that's a monstrous buffet you know? So you know you do a few at a time or one at a time and things that are picked up and it's a wonderful, wonderful, wonderful resource. And I certainly can't thank you enough.

MR: Well I'm glad you're part of it now.

NM: Thank you so very, very much.

MR: All right. I'll pause us here and we'll say our good-byes.

NM: God bless and bop on.